

When Fighting Stops Working

READING SAMPLE

Chapter One from the final print edition.

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Developed through human-AI collaboration. Excerpt only.

CHAPTER 1 THE HAMMER

For most of my life, fighting worked.

That is the problem.

If fighting had failed me early, I might have learned something else. Patience, maybe. Moderation. Yoga.

Instead, fighting kept paying.

Get knocked down? Get up.

Somebody bigger than you? Hit him harder.

No money? Work.

Nobody coming to save you?

Good.

Saves time waiting.

I got so good at surviving bad situations that it took me decades to notice a fairly obvious flaw in the system:

I kept having bad situations.

There is a point where toughness stops being courage and becomes a subscription service. You keep paying every month because you have forgotten you are allowed to cancel.

Nobody tells you that when you are young.

They tell you not to quit.

They put it on T-shirts.

NEVER QUIT.

FIGHT THROUGH IT.

PAIN IS WEAKNESS LEAVING THE BODY.

That last one was clearly invented by somebody who never had to get out of bed the morning after football practice.

Pain can mean a lot of things. Sometimes it means you are tired. Sometimes it means growth costs something. Sometimes it means, Hey, genius, something appears to be broken.

I loved those sayings anyway.

Of course I did.

They matched the equipment I had.

If life handed some people a toolbox, I apparently showed up with one item.

A hammer.

Fortunately, a hammer is a pretty useful tool. You can drive nails, break things apart, build things, defend yourself, make noise, get somebody's attention.

And if the world you grow up in contains enough nails, you can become extremely proud of your hammer.

I did.

Football loved the hammer.

Football may be the finest legal institution ever invented for a young man with too much anger and nowhere respectable to put it.

The rules are magnificent.

For a few seconds at a time, another human being stands directly in front of you trying to impose his will on you. Your job is to prevent that.

Better yet, everybody applauds when you do.

Coaches yell. Teammates slap your helmet. People in the stands get to their feet.

Somewhere along the line I discovered that several hundred pounds of man trying to run through me made more sense than a lot of the rest of life.

There was a whistle.

There was a scoreboard.

There were lines painted on the ground.

You knew where you stood.

Most problems outside football do not provide this courtesy.

Grief does not line up across from you.

Fear does not wear a numbered jersey.

Money trouble does not tell you the snap count.

A broken relationship does not get penalized fifteen yards for unnecessary roughness.

Life cheats constantly.

And yet I kept using football rules.

Lower your shoulder.

Move your feet.

Don't let him see you're tired.

Finish the play.

Then finish the next one.

Those rules carried me a long way.

That is what makes this complicated.

People like clean lessons. We like looking backward and dividing everything into good and bad, healthy and unhealthy, strength and weakness.

Life rarely cooperates.

Sometimes the same quality that saves you becomes the quality you later have to learn how to manage.

My willingness to keep going was real strength.

It was also dangerous as hell.

Football reinforced it because playing hurt often worked.

At Ellsworth, I learned that pain could be ignored, negotiated with, and even rewarded.

That lesson followed me.

Later, at South Carolina, my knee finally made the decision for me. I tore my MCL in the Tennessee game, had surgery the next morning, and the football road ended.

There was no amount of wanting it that could make the ligament untorn.

No speech.

No extra set.

No harder hit.

Reality had made the call.

That should have taught me something immediately.

It did not.

I am an excellent student when the lesson agrees with me.

The others take longer.

What football had taught me - correctly - was that people often quit before they have actually reached their limit.

What I failed to understand was that this does not mean every limit is imaginary.

That difference would take me years.

Because once you become known as the guy who can take a hit, people stop asking whether you should have to.

Eventually you stop asking too.

You become proud of carrying what somebody else would put down.

Then one day you are staggering down the road with a refrigerator on your back while explaining to everybody how strong you are.

They may even be impressed.

Nobody asks the useful question.

Kevin, why are you carrying a refrigerator?

That is the question I wish I had learned earlier.

Not:

Can I endure this?

I already knew that answer.

I could endure a lot.

The better question was:

Why am I enduring this?

One measures capacity.

The other requires judgment.

For me, capacity was easier.

Judgment might require admitting that the smartest move was not to push harder.

Sometimes it meant stopping.

Sometimes changing direction.

Sometimes putting the damn refrigerator down.

That can feel suspiciously like defeat when you have spent your life treating endurance as a virtue.

The first time you consider walking away from something you probably could survive, a voice appears.

Coward.

I know that voice.

He has been living rent-free upstairs for years and remains extremely confident for a man who has never paid a bill.

He has a small vocabulary.

Stay.

Fight.

Prove them wrong.

Give it another week.

Take another hit.

You handled worse before.

That last one is powerful because it is usually true.

You handled worse before.

Survivors hear that as proof.

Maybe it is.

But proof of what?

That you can suffer?

Congratulations.

We may have established that sufficiently.

For years I confused capacity with obligation. If I could take something, I thought maybe I should. If I could fix something, maybe it was my responsibility to fix it. If a plan failed, my instinct was not to question the plan.

More effort.

More calls.

More hours.

More force.

More hammer.

And here is the irritating part:

Sometimes it worked.

That kept the system alive.

If doubling down failed every time, even I would have caught on eventually.

But persistence has paid me often enough that I learned to trust persistence before I learned to evaluate what I was persisting at.

Those are not the same skill.

One asks:

Can I keep going?

The other asks:

Should I?

I still trust the first question.

I just no longer let it vote alone.

There are absolutely times when quitting early will cost you the life you could have had.

I know that too.

If I had walked away every time something hurt,
embarrassed me, frightened me, or seemed unlikely, my
life would look very different.

Some things deserve stubbornness.

A kid trying to get out of a bad situation.

A student trying to finish.

An athlete with another rep in him.

A person trying to get sober.

A salesman making the next call after twenty people told
him no.

A dream that is difficult because difficult things are
sometimes difficult.

This book is not an argument for becoming fragile.

I still get nervous around the word soft. Somewhere in my
head it has always sounded too much like unprotected.

I am beginning to suspect those are different things.

Strength matters.

Endurance matters.

Discipline matters.

So does knowing what they are serving.

That last part is where I got into trouble.

I spent years treating strength as if strength itself were
the objective.

It isn't.

Strength is a tool.

The hammer is not the house.

That sounds obvious when I write it.

Many of life's expensive lessons do.

The harder question is knowing when you are looking at a nail.

That is where this book begins.

Not with the claim that fighting is wrong.

Fighting saved me.

Not with the claim that perseverance is overrated.

I owe too much of my life to perseverance to say that.

The question is what happens when an old strength becomes automatic.

When persistence stops being a choice and becomes identity.

When every problem starts looking like proof of whether you are tough enough.

When leaving feels humiliating even after staying has stopped producing anything except more staying.

When helping becomes carrying.

When work becomes worth.

When pain becomes evidence that you must prove something.

When the hammer is so familiar in your hand that you stop noticing you are holding it.

That is where judgment has to enter.

And judgment is less satisfying than toughness because it does not always give you a heroic answer.

Sometimes the answer is fight like hell.

Sometimes the answer is wait.

Sometimes apologize.

Sometimes ask for help.

Sometimes let somebody else carry their own weight.

Sometimes admit you do not know.

Sometimes stop.

There is no T-shirt for this.

USE THE APPROPRIATE TOOL FOR THE SITUATION.

Terrible merchandise.

Pretty good life advice.

I am still learning it.

I still occasionally grab the hammer because it is nearby.

I still feel the pull to prove I can endure something before asking whether enduring it serves any purpose.

But I am getting better at one question:

What does this actually require from me?

Not what would make me look toughest.

Not what I have always done.

Not what worked twenty years ago.

What does this require?

The rest of this book is my attempt to answer that question.

Where the hammer came from.

Why it worked.

Why I loved it.

What it cost.

Why putting it down can feel terrifying.

How to tell the difference between a worthwhile hard thing and a harmful pattern.

What happens when your body, your relationships, or your life begins giving you information your identity does not want to hear.

And what you do with all that strength when fighting is no longer the only job available.

Because I still believe in fighting your way through.

Absolutely.

When the wall is real and the other side matters, fight like hell.

Just look around when you get through.

Do not spend the rest of your life searching for another wall.

There are other things to build.

There are people to love.

There are ideas to try.

There are places you have not seen.

There are mornings that do not need to be survived.

And if you have carried the hammer long enough, the strangest discovery may be this:

Your hands were never made only for fighting.

They can build too.

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